



NIGERIA PEOPLES AND CULTURE



‘LEGITIMATE’ TRADE TO FORMAL OCCUPATION

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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

At the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Discuss the Annexation of Lagos - 1861.
- Discuss the Rise of Legitimate Trade.
- Examine the events after the end of the slave trade, leading to company rule and eventually colonialism.



THE END OF THE SLAVE TRADE

By 1840, the Bight of Benin was the last centre of the slave trade in West Africa, and Lagos was the leading slave port.

Trade with Europe in Palm oil, ivory, and other "legitimate" commodities was expanding.

Beecroft was appointed in 1849 for the purpose of control and supervision. It marked the beginning of Britain's direct influence in Nigeria.





THE ANNEXATION OF LAGOS - 1861

- The rulership of Lagos and the feud between Kosoko and Akitoye

In 1851, the British signed a treaty with Kosoko to end the slave trade and embrace 'legitimate' trade.

Kosoko's refusal and the consequent bombardment

On December 29, 1851, Akitoye regained the seat of Lagos as Kosoko fled to Epe.

The annexation of Lagos in 1861





THE RISE OF LEGITIMATE TRADE

Immediately after the bombardment, more ships began coming to Lagos to buy palm oil and other produce.

In 1852, a treaty was signed regarding the protection of British traders, the right to trade, and the erecting of storage facilities in Lagos.

In return, European merchants were to pay import and export duties.





THE EXPEDITIONS AND COMPANY RULE

- Macgregor Laird's expedition of 1857

Three trading ports were established in the Delta as a result of this expedition: Ado, Onitsha, and Gbebe.

Laird granted admiralty in the Delta.

Laird's formation of a joint stock company in 1858—the Central African Company

Laird's death in 1861



COMPANY RULE

In 1862, the floating of the River Niger Navigation and Trading Company.

The Company of African Merchants

Proliferation of companies and the advantage to locals

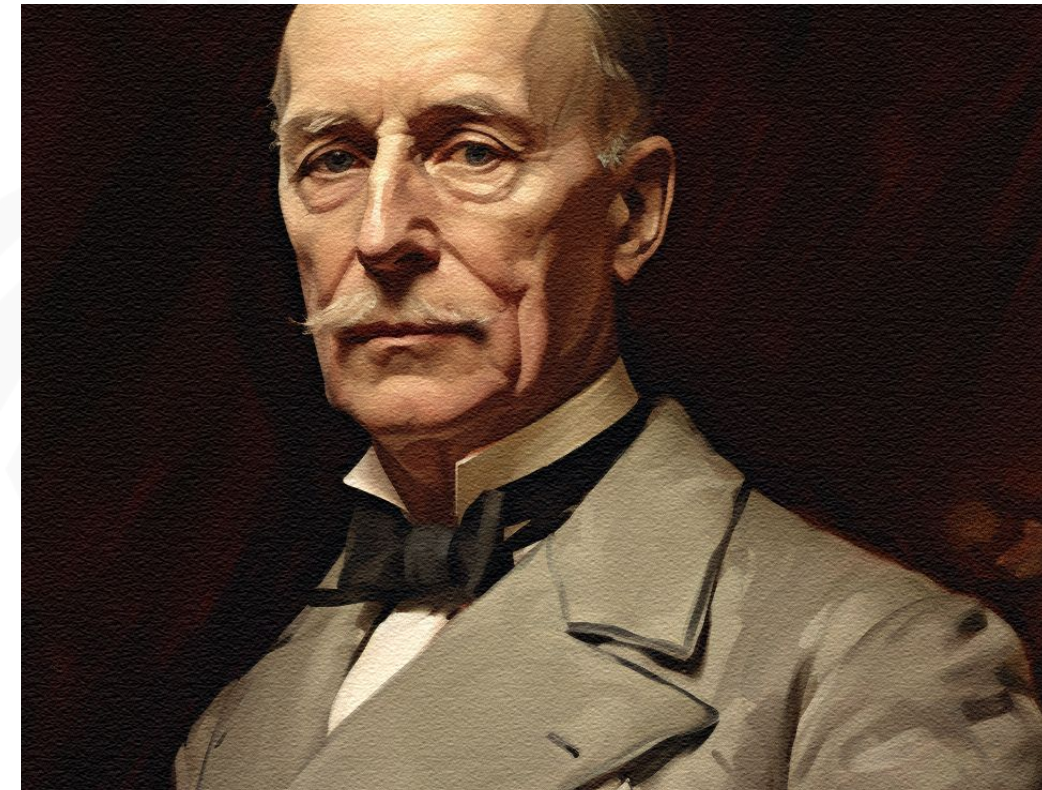
Big companies like the West African Company, Alexander Miller Bros, Mr. James Pinnock and the Central African Company of London took charge of the Delta trade.



COMPANY RULE

The company's amalgamation and the creation of the United African Company under Sir George Goldie-Taubman was later known as the National African Company after buying two rival French firms.

By 1882, the company had become powerful enough to control large areas of the Niger Delta but not powerful enough to monopolise the trade.





COMPANY RULE

In order to support the NAC, the British government instructed Consul Hewett to embark on a treaty-making tour in 1884.

A lot of chiefs placed themselves under British protection.

Sphere of Influence and the Berlin Conference



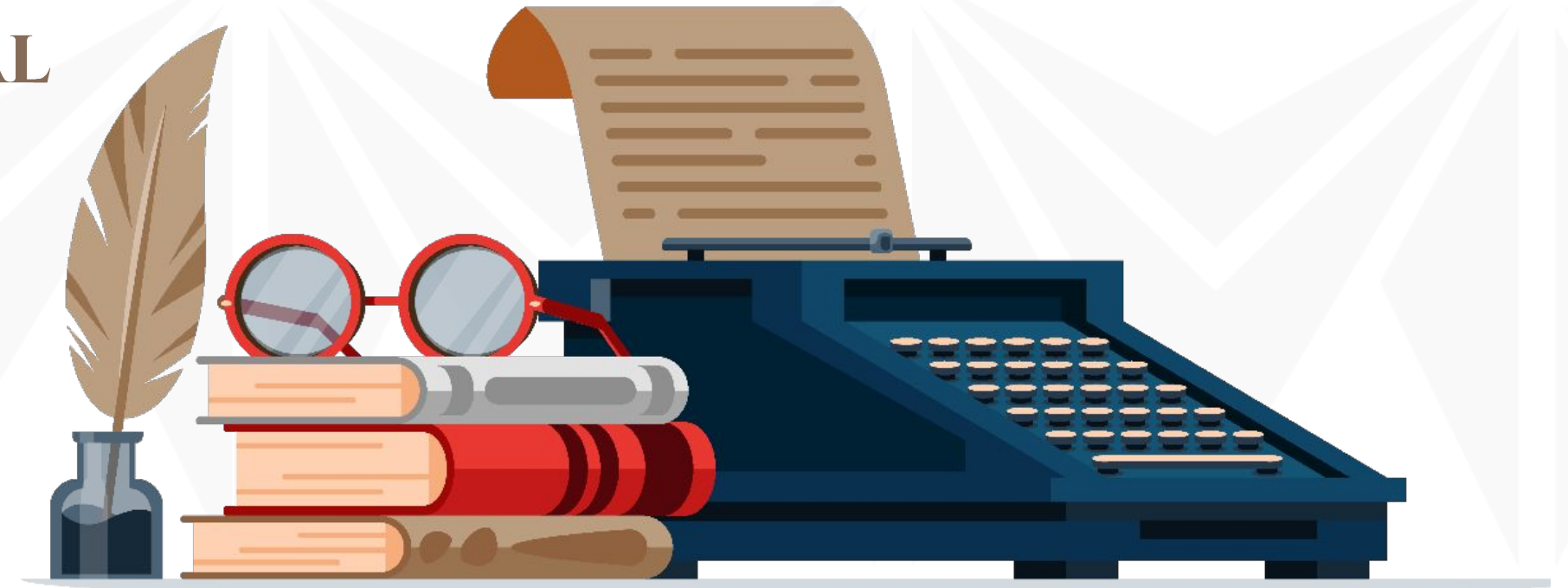


THE ROYAL CHARTER AND THE ROYAL NIGER COMPANY

NAC applied for a charter in 1881 but was refused on the grounds of a lack of capacity.

By 1882, NAC had raised its capital to 1 million pounds, but the presence of French firms made a British Charter impossible.

By 1886, NAC was granted a Royal Charter and became known as the Royal Niger Company.





POP UP QUIZ

In what year did the Royal Niger Company (formerly NAC) finally receive a Royal Charter?

- A) 1881
- B) 1882
- C) 1886
- D) 1890



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The Royal Niger Company (formerly NAC) applied for a charter in 1881 but was refused. In 1882, they had raised their capital, but a British Charter was still impossible due to the presence of French firms. However, by 1886, the Royal Niger Company was finally granted a Royal Charter, and this is when it officially became known as the Royal Niger Company.



ROYAL NIGER COMPANY (RNC)

RNC operated as a trading company and administrator.

It paid dividends solely from trade profits.

By 1887, the RNC controlled all the territories in the basin of the Niger.





RNC's STRUCTURE

The company's strategy was to build a trade monopoly in the Niger territories over which it had control.

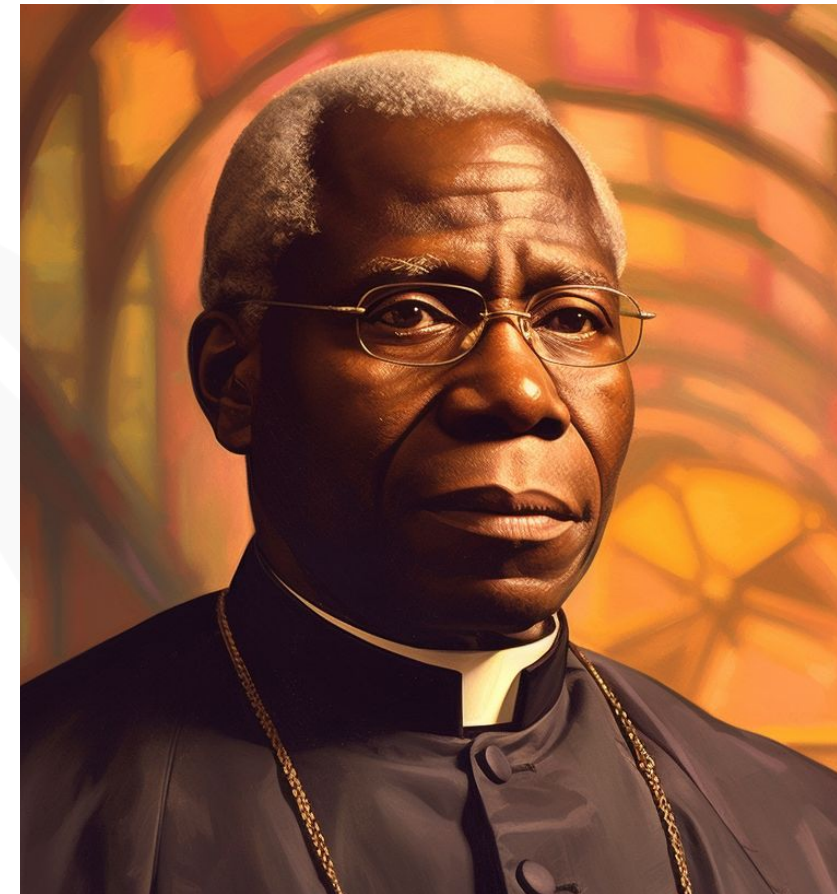
The RNC bought competing companies, chased them with high taxes, monopolised the supply of imported goods, and manipulated the prices of African produce.





CRITICISMS OF THE RNC

- Harry Johnston's criticism
- Ajayi Crowther
- Hoenigsberg



RNC had the favour of the Colonial Secretary – Salisbury and thus, the criticisms did not do much damage.



OIL RIVER PROTECTORATE (ORP)

- The Oil River Protectorate was established in 1884 after the Berlin Conference.
- It consisted of 7 districts: Bonny, Forcados, Old Calabar, New Calabar, Benin, Brass, and Opobo.
- Request for the amalgamation of ORP and RNC and the opposition to the request
- ORP was renamed the Niger Coast Protectorate in 1893.





THE DECLINE OF THE RNC

A number of reasons are responsible for the decline of the RNC, including:

- Alliances of opponents of the RNC
- Appointment of Sir Ralph Moor as Consul of ORP in 1891
- Price war
- Smuggling





THE DECLINE OF THE RNC

By 1895, two significant but unrelated events had combined to weaken the RNC:

- Appointment of Joseph Chamberlain as Colonial Secretary
- The raid on Akassa by the Brass people

The Kirk Commission of Enquiry was set up to look into the cause of the Akassa raid.

Revocation of RNC's Charter





SUMMARY

In this lesson, we have:

- Discussed the Annexation of Lagos - 1861.
- Discussed the Rise of Legitimate Trade.
- Examined the events after the end of the slave trade, leading to company rule and eventually colonialism.



FURTHER READING

- National Archives Ibadan, “The Historical Element in Nigerian Public Records: The Niger Territories, 1830-1900,” *Archival Memorandum*, No. 26, (1940), 5.
- National Archives Ibadan, *The Making of Modern Nigeria*, 1965, 150.
- S. O. Biobaku, *The Egba and Their Neighbours, 1842-1872* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1957)



REFERENCES

- Bernard Schnapper, *La politique et le commerce français dans le Golfe de Guinée de 1838 à 1871* (Paris: Mouton, 1961)
- E. Keazor, *Nigeria and the Royal Niger Company: The Real Story* (2014).
- L. C. Dioka and Siyan Oyeweso, "Intergroup Relations in a Frontier State: The Case of Badagry," in *Badagry: A Study in History, Culture, and Traditions of an Ancient City*, ed. G. O. Ogunremi, M. O. Opeloye, and Siyan Oyeweso (Ibadan: Rex Charles, 1994)



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THANK
YOU